apparent value. It was also nearer to the critical oil-rich Middle East. Therefore, American and British diplomats sought stability in the region. But the belief that a Kashmir settlement was necessary to achieve that objective would cause serious differences with India.[5]

At that stage, India's fledgling democratic experiment gave it only minimal symbolic value in the US strategic framework. The nature of a country's government was not on the list of characteristics that made a country important to the US. Officials such as Kennan believed that the type of government within states was not necessarily relevant in determining the US relationship with them. It was in American interests to have at least some nations remain democratic, but the US itself could serve to demonstrate the benefits of democracy. Economic recovery in the democratic countries of Western Europe could further serve to prove that democracy and economic progress could coexist.[6]

The lack of interest in India came with a relative lack of concern about its foreign policy, even what George Marshall, secretary of state in 1947, called its "intention to pursue an independent but cooperative policy." There was also little apprehension that communists would gain much ground within India. Thus most American policymakers, lacking the time, expertise, and interest, were satisfied with Britain taking the lead in shaping Anglo-American policy toward India.[7]

Developments in 1949, however, would bring Asia, in general, and India, in particular, to Washington's attention. Two events—the Soviet nuclear test in August and the Chinese Communist Party's establishment of the People's Republic in October—shook the faith that strongpoint defense would be sufficient to ensure American security. The weakening of the American nuclear deterrent and China going communist would make not just Europe but also Asia seem more vulnerable. And with the perception of a shift in the power balance, Kennan's view that China was not vital would became less resonant.

Initially in 1949, as the Guomindang (GMD) regime in China, led by Jiang Jieshi (Chiang Kai-shek), was collapsing under the weight of the Chinese Communist Party's onslaught, Truman and Acheson perceived no good options. They supported Jieshi's regime, but they believed it was partly responsible for the situation and the GMD's imminent collapse. And they had no desire to increase aid that was unlikely to help. In July 1949,